

DISTRUST AND DESPERATION

The frosty relationship between Nehru and Jinnah, both fastidious and vain, altered the history of the sub-continent

By **SUNIL KHILNANI**

Partition is the greatest still-running 'whodunnit' of Indian history. Was the deed done at the Viceregal Lodge in Shimla or on a Calcutta street corner? At a Bombay press conference, or in a cigar smoke-filled Whitehall parlour? And was it the immaculately dressed lawyer with his briefcase, the eccentric spiritualist with his *dhoti*, the impetuous politician with his pen, or the Viceroy himself, with his map and compass?

Who, exactly, was the victim of this crime? India? Its Muslim, Sikh or other minorities? Its Hindu majority? Countless families? A revered map? Whatever or whoever it might be, someone must be held responsible. And Indians have been brought up to believe it was one man, Mohammad Ali Jinnah, the malevolent interloper, the joker in the pack, who hijacked Indian history from its destined, *akhand* end. His perfidy somehow ensures India's purity.

Jinnah's bald caricature is ironic, for the most striking thing about the man is the opacity of his intentions and beliefs. His protagonists—Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru, Louis Mountbatten—all consummate proto-bloggers and inexhaustible confessional tellers. Jinnah, though, covered his traces. He left no diaries, wrote few revealing letters. His actions thus invite interpretation and speculation—even while they defy it.

Historians have, in fact, freely interpreted the role of Jinnah in ways that deftly skim the rug from under the founding national myths of both Pakistan and India. A quarter of a century ago, Pakistani scholar Ayesha Jalal, a student of Cambridge historian Anil Seal, argued that Jinnah never intended to create Pakistan as a sovereign nation-state. His purpose, Jalal claimed, was to protect

the interests of Indian Muslims by wresting greater autonomy for provincial governments over which Muslims could hope to have greater control. Jinnah feared the Congress leaders' ambition to create a strong central state, which might have then fallen into the hands of those claiming to represent the interests of Hindu majorities, and effectively disenfranchised Indian Muslims. In his political manoeuvring with the Congress leaders and the British, Jinnah used the call for an independent Pakistan merely as a bluff—a threat to get the more decentralised political order he wanted. To his dismay, that bluff was called.

In this interpretation, the impulse to create Pakistan came not from the Muslim League but from a Congress leadership overly impatient to acquire control of the state, and under pressure from the communal Hindus within their own movement (one decisive source of pressure, historian Joya Chatterji has convincingly argued, was Bengal's *bhadralok* who were determined to hive off the eastern, poorer and Muslim-dominated districts of the province.)

Yet such scholarly complications over the roles played by Jinnah and Congress leaders like Nehru, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and Gandhi have failed to penetrate the wider Indian political imagination. It seems we still want our settled pantheons of heroes and villains. And it's not just the BJP's Sushma Swaraj and Murli Manohar Joshi or the RSS's Ram Madhav

who are unwilling to have their illusions disturbed. The Congress too prefers to cleave fervently to its homiletic myths.

That's why we should particularly welcome Jaswant Singh's study of Jinnah. It marks the first effort by a member of the political establishment to ask bold and awkward questions about our foundation. And it invites

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